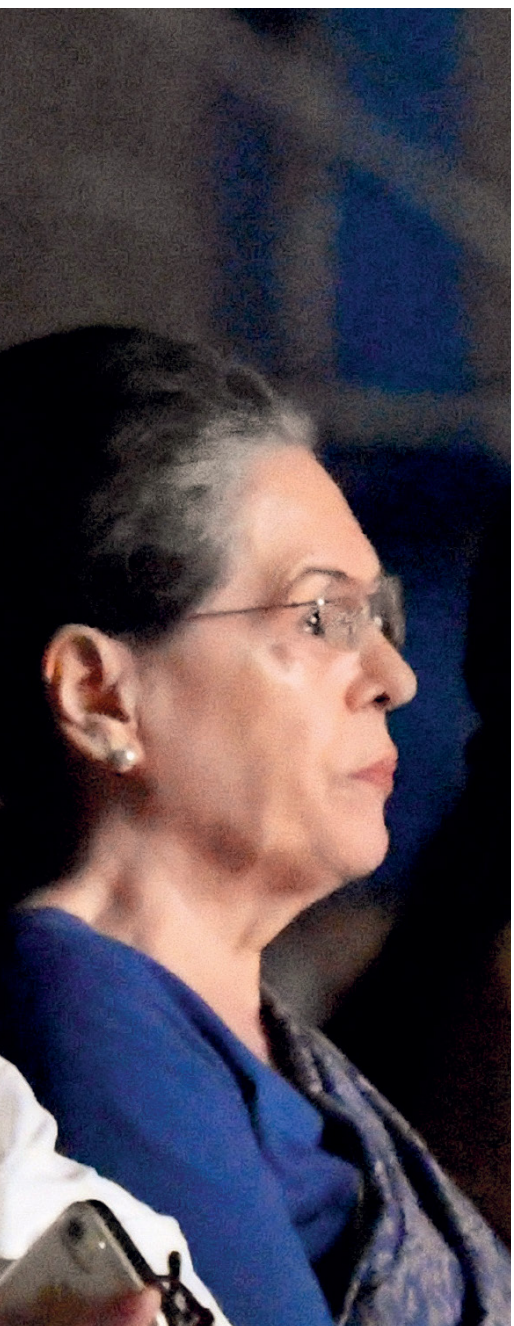


ANI

IT WAS ONE MORE EPISODE IN A long-running series of embarrassments for the Congress, and it could have done without the usual round of dire prognoses—ahead of a major decision on what its leadership should look like. On August 26, in a five-page-long letter announcing his resignation from the party, former Union minister Ghulam Nabi Azad launched a scathing attack on Rahul Gandhi, de facto head of the Congress, singling him out for its dismal performance in the past eight years. Several leaders have indeed blamed Rahul while quitting the Congress, but this was the first time a party veteran of 50 years has held the Gandhi scion accountable for its electoral debacles, on record.

The unprecedented criticism came two days before the Congress Working Committee (CWC) announced the schedule for the polls to elect the next Congress president. Several Congress insiders claim the letter, as parting shots go, was meant to draw blood: to stall any possibility of Rahul resuming the party's reins. It need not have made the effort. Tired of the constant criticism over his leadership style and the Gandhi family's grip over the party, the former Congress chief has told colleagues on multiple occasions that he wants a non-Gandhi as president.

Yet, there have been desperate attempts for the past few weeks—as the election schedule inched closer—to convince Rahul to return to the top post. "Rahul Gandhi is the most acceptable Congress leader with pan-India support," says Abhishek Manu Singhvi, third-term Rajya Sabha MP and CWC member. "That's why all Congress workers want him back. To question his candidature, by the very people who preach inner-party democracy, is itself anti-democratic."

But Rahul has been unrelenting. On August 5, when senior Congress leaders, including the Gandhi family, were protesting price rise and unemployment on the streets of Delhi, some of them tried to persuade Rahul. "This is not the party I want to lead," the Congress scion shot back. Azad's letter, says a CWC member, will give him further excuse to stay away.

RAHUL'S MAIN GROUSE IS AGAINST SOME SENIOR LEADERS WHO CAN SABOTAGE DECISIONS THAT ARE AGAINST THEIR INTERESTS

WHY RAHUL IS UNWILLING TO LEAD THE PARTY

At the root of Rahul's reluctance is his disenchantment with some senior Congress leaders. He believes these leaders, who have considerable clout in the party, have the potential to sabotage any decision if it is against their interests. When he resigned in 2019, owning responsibility for the party's loss in the Lok Sabha election, he named some leaders for being more interested in ensuring tickets for their children than fighting the BJP and Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Rahul had categorically stated that he stood alone in the fight against Modi and did not get the expected support from seniors. He cites that as the reason why he doesn't want anyone from his family—mother Sonia or sister Priyanka—to take official charge. "While every decision is taken in the name of Gandhis, it's not that the Gandhis give their consent to every decision. When things don't go in their favour, senior leaders resort to subterfuge, making it difficult to implement decisions. But the blame comes to rest with the Gandhis," says a close Rahul aide.

His detractors dismiss this as an excuse to avoid accountability. "The family simply wants a puppet as party president who will take the blame for anything that goes wrong while the three Gandhis will be the real power centre," says a leader who was part of the group of 23 senior Congress leaders that had written a letter to Sonia in August 2020, demanding